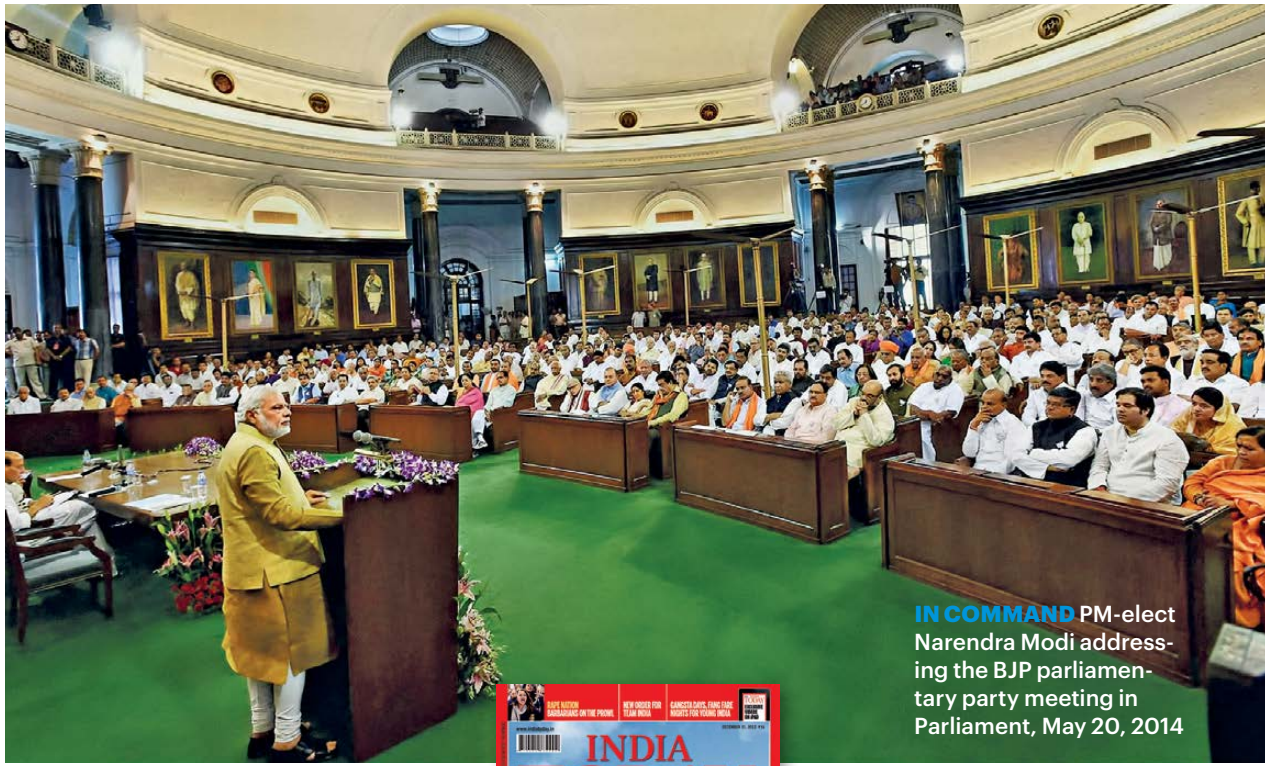


PTI

IN COMMAND PM-elect Narendra Modi addressing the BJP parliamentary party meeting in Parliament, May 20, 2014

Indian politics witnessed the steady rise of a leader who transformed personal controversy into political capital and regional dominance into a national mandate. Narendra Modi's ascent was neither sudden nor accidental. It was the product of repeated electoral validation in Gujarat, a relentless cultivation of image and narrative, and a moment of national exhaustion with drift, corruption and diffidence at the Centre.

In the mid-2000s, Modi was still a deeply polarising chief minister, carrying the indelible shadow of the 2002 Gujarat riots. Nationally, he was viewed with suspicion by sections of the political class, the intelligentsia and even allies within the BJP. Yet, instead of retreating into defensiveness, Modi recalibrated. He shifted the axis of debate from identity to aspiration, recasting himself as a development-driven administrator who could deliver growth, infrastructure and efficiency.

Gujarat became Modi's political laboratory. Successive assembly victories in 2007 and 2012 were not merely electoral wins but referendums on what came to be known as the 'Gujarat model'. High growth rates, industrial summits, uninterrupted power supply and aggressive courting of investment allowed Modi to project governance as ideology. These elections also marked his mastery of political communication. Modi personalised campaigns, marginalised local leadership and turned every contest into a direct choice between himself and an abstract, often faceless Opposition.

By the early 2010s, Modi's influence had outgrown Gujarat. As the UPA government at the Centre became mired in corruption scandals, policy paralysis and economic slowdown, Modi positioned himself as the antithesis of indecision. His 2014 campaign was unlike any India had seen before. It fused presidential-style projection with grassroots mobilisation, social media with mass rallies, and development rhetoric with sharp political contrast. The slogan *'Abki baar, Modi sarkar'* was a declaration of political centralisation in a system long accustomed to coalitions and compromises.

His landslide victory in May 2014 was historic. The BJP's single-party majority shattered long-held assumptions about coalition inevitability in post-1989 India. His rise marked the end of an era of hesitant leadership and the beginning of a more centralised, personality-driven phase of Indian democracy, the consequences of which would shape the country long after the victory celebrations faded. ■



Force Modi on a Roll
Dec. 31, 2012

"A new legend in Indian politics is being written on the banks of the Sabarmati. As Narendra Damodardas Modi soars over the wreckage of his challengers, it is more than a triumphant testament of the politics of prosperity. In a country where the attitudes of its ruling class are invariably incompatible with the aspirations of its people, his hat-trick in Gandhinagar essays the possibilities of leadership and the rewards of conviction."